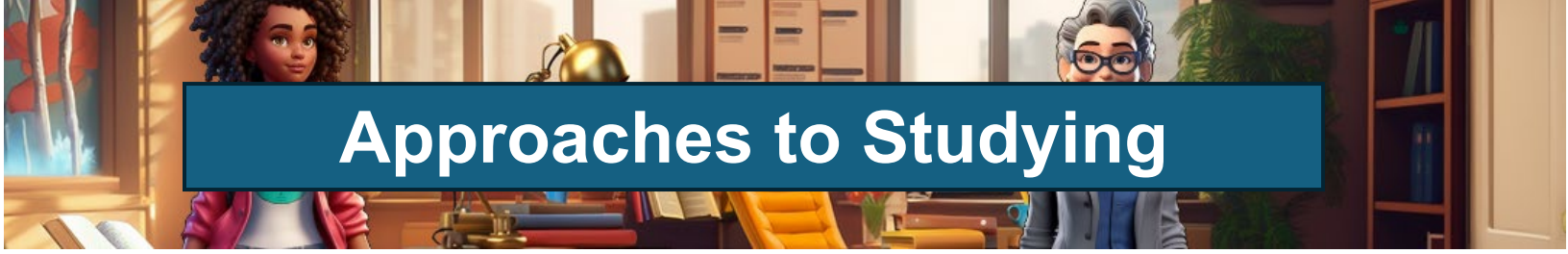


Approaches to Studying

Many students make two mistakes when studying: Cramming and not mixing up materials.

Cramming may help in the short term but it creates a traffic jam in your memory causing you to forget material in the long-term.

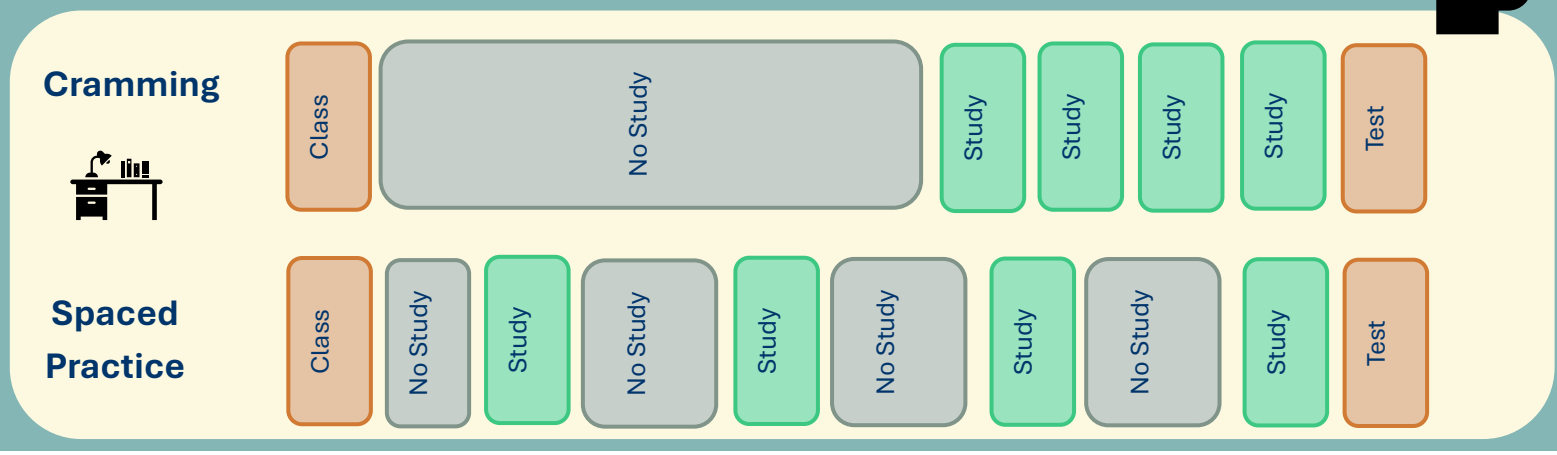
Spaced studying allows time for information to move from short-term to long-term memory and reducing a traffice jam.

Also, mixing up different topics (interleaving) within a single study session encourages the brain to work harder and leads to stronger long-term memory.

The following two strategies for studying help to prevent a traffic jam and reduce panic the night before an exam when you are trying to memorize a lot of information

1 Spaced practice

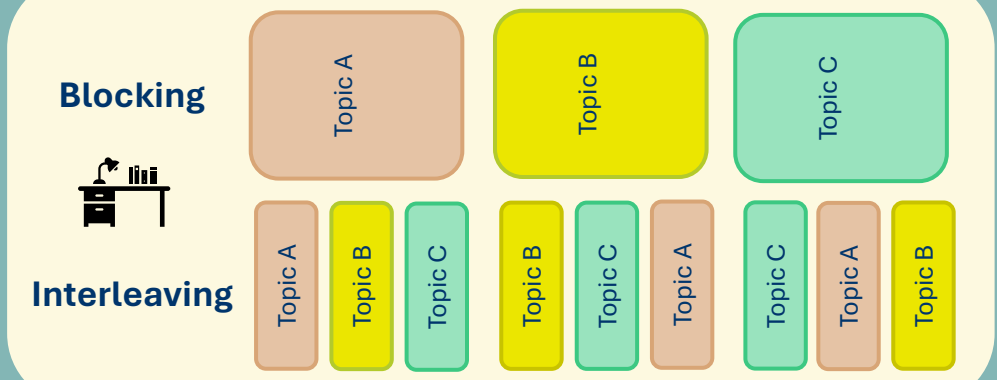
Space out studying over multiple session across time. Review information even if you don't have a test so it can get into your long-term memory.



2 Interleaving.

How: Switch between ideas or different types of problems while you study to make links between the different ideas.

Why: It avoids studying one idea for too long. Going back over the ideas again in different order can strengthen your understanding.



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